

NIRVAN SUTRA

Nirvan Sutra

Chapter 4: The Layers of Ego

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A course chapter for sincere seekers

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Chapter 4: The Layers of Ego

First Section - The Root Mistake: “I am the body-mind”

In the journey so far, the seeker has taken three important steps. In the first chapter, the seeker turned inward and examined the body, the mind, the experiencer, and the quiet knowing presence that this course calls the witness. In the second chapter, the seeker looked outward and began to understand maya and the world: the world appears in experience, it matters in daily life, yet it is not the final truth. In the third chapter, the seeker learned how witness-consciousness can be remembered in the middle of life - in relationships, work, success, failure, and deep emotions.

Now the fourth chapter turns toward the knot that holds the whole confusion together. That knot is ego.

When people hear the word ego, they often think it only means pride. Someone who thinks too highly of himself, looks down on others, wants praise, and always wants to be right - this is usually called ego. That is one form of ego, but in this course, ego means something deeper.

Here, ego means the sense of “I” that takes the body, mind, thoughts, name, story, and role to be its real identity. In simple words, ego is the root mistake that says: “I am this body-mind.” From this mistake the experiencer is born. The experiencer says, “This happened to me,” “I am hurt,” “I succeeded,” “I failed,” “I had a spiritual experience,” “This is my story.” Now we must look at this “I” very patiently.

The first misunderstanding to clear is this: ego does not only say, “I am great.” Ego can also say, “I am very small.” “I am superior” can be ego, but “I am worthless” can also be ego. “Everyone should respect me” can be ego, and “No

one should see me because I am weak” can also be ego. In both cases, the center is the same - the story of “me.”

Sometimes this “I” wants to become big. Sometimes it becomes small and sits inside its suffering. Sometimes it wants respect. Sometimes it holds tightly to the story of its insult. Sometimes it wants victory. Sometimes it turns defeat into identity. So to understand ego only as pride is incomplete. The root of ego is identification with body, mind, name, role, and story.

The first and most obvious grip of ego is identification with the body. “I am beautiful,” “I am not beautiful,” “I am young,” “I am old,” “I am healthy,” “I am sick,” “I am strong,” “I am weak.” In practical life, the body must be cared for. If the body is ill, treatment is needed. If the body is tired, rest is needed. Spirituality is not neglecting the body. But to take the condition of the body as the whole of “me” is the beginning of ego.

The body changes. It belongs to nature. It will age, become tired, become healthy, become weak, become strong, become ill, recover, and change again. These are states of the body. The witness knows these states. Ego says, “I am this state.” That is the difference.

After the body, the second grip of ego is the mind. “My thoughts are me,” “My emotions are me,” “My preferences are me,” “My opinions are me,” “My memories are me.” Thoughts arise in the mind, emotions arise, memories appear, imagination moves, desires come and go. We have already seen that the mind is a changing flow. But ego takes hold of this flow and says, “This is me.”

If someone disagrees with our opinion, ego feels wounded because it has turned that opinion into identity. If someone does not fulfill our desire, ego becomes hurt because it has turned the desire into an extension of “me.” There is nothing wrong with the mind having opinions, preferences, plans, and decisions. The problem begins when ego stamps every movement of the

mind with the seal: “This is me.” A thought arising is the movement of mind. Making identity from that thought is ego.

Now it becomes easier to see how the experiencer is formed. The witness only knows. It knows the condition of the body. It knows the movement of the mind. It knows thoughts, emotions, pleasure, pain. It does not become them. But when identity joins the body-mind, the experiencer appears.

Sadness comes. The witness knows, “Sadness is being experienced.” Ego says, “I am sad.” In that moment, the experiencer is born. Anger comes. The witness knows, “A wave of anger is arising.” Ego says, “I am angry; I must respond.” In that moment, the experiencer becomes active. Success comes. The witness knows, “There is joy and the experience of success.” Ego says, “I am great.” In that moment, the experiencer makes success its own.

So ego and experiencer are closely connected. Ego is the root mistaken identity - “I am the body-mind.” The experiencer is the personal “I” that arises from this identity and claims experiences as its own. The witness can know both. This is very important. Ego is not something to be killed immediately. The experiencer is not an enemy. First they must be seen, because what is clearly seen begins to lose its grip.

A simple example may help. An actor plays the role of a king on stage. He wears a crown, sits on a throne, gives orders, and receives respect. In the play, this role has meaning. The problem begins only if the actor goes home after the play and still believes he is truly the king. The role was useful, but it was not his real identity.

Life is similar. You may be a father, mother, teacher, trader, seeker, guide, student, or friend. These roles have value in daily life. They must be fulfilled with love and responsibility. But to take any role as your final identity is ego. Play the role, but do not become the role.

Ego is also made from name and personal story. Every person carries a story: “This happened to me,” “I struggled a lot,” “I was never respected,” “I built

everything alone,” “No one understood me.” Many events in these stories may be true. The question of inquiry is not whether events happened. The question is: am I only my story? A story lives in memory, and memory appears in the mind. The witness can know the story too. The story may describe life, but it is not your final self.

When seekers begin to see ego, they sometimes become afraid. They think, “There is so much ego in me. I must not be a good seeker.” This too can become a subtle trap. Blaming yourself for seeing ego may become another story of ego: “I am a bad seeker.” So great gentleness is needed here. See ego, but do not hate it. Recognize it, but do not fight it. Understand its layers, but do not suppress them.

If ego says, “I am the body-mind,” who knows that statement? If ego says, “I need respect,” where is that desire known? Here the direction of witness-consciousness opens again. The witness does not fight ego. The witness knows ego. Like a lamp that illuminates the objects in a room, witness-consciousness reveals the layers of ego. Earlier we were being moved by ego. Now we begin to see ego. This seeing is what loosens its grip.

In this first section, we have begun to understand the root identity of ego. Ego is not merely pride. It is the basic “I” notion that takes body, mind, name, role, and story to be the real self. For now, remember this: do not make ego your enemy. Do not hide it. Do not blame yourself when it is seen. Simply recognize it.

Practice for Today

Today, notice one moment when the sense of “I” becomes very strong. It may happen when someone does not accept your view, when someone praises you, criticizes you, or when you feel you deserved respect. Then ask: What was this “I” identifying with - body, thought, role, result, or

story? What did this “I” want - respect, security, control, love, recognition, or to be proven right? Can I see this rising “I”? Do not try to make the answer beautiful. Just see. Seeing ego is the first distance from ego.

Second Section - The Ego of Role, Image, and Story

In the previous section we saw the root knot of ego. Now we will look at some of its more visible layers. These layers are very common. Every person lives them in one form or another, so there is no need to be afraid or guilty when they are seen. We only need to recognize where the “I” attaches itself. In this section we will look at three layers: the ego of role, the ego of image, and the ego of story.

Every person plays many roles: parent, child, partner, friend, teacher, businessperson, student, seeker, guide. Roles are not the problem. They are necessary for life. A parent must care for a child. A teacher must teach. A worker must work responsibly. The problem is not in the role. The problem is in turning the role into “me.”

When someone says, “I am a father,” that is fine in practical life. But when the inner feeling becomes, “Because I am the father, my word must always be final,” the role has become ego. When someone says, “I am a teacher,” that is fine. But if he cannot bear being questioned because “I know,” the role has become ego. When someone says, “I am a seeker,” that too is fine. But if he feels higher than others because he is spiritual, the seeker-role has become another costume of ego.

A role is like a garment. It must be worn and used, but it must not be mistaken for the body. A person may wear a uniform for work and remove it at home. The uniform is useful, but it is not identity. Roles are like that. In

witness-consciousness the seeker begins to see, “The father-role is speaking,” “The teacher-role is active,” “The seeker-role is being protected.” Seeing this does not weaken the role. It purifies it.

There is a difference between playing a role and becoming a role. A mother caring for a child is playing a role. A mother believing that every choice of the child must be under her control is becoming the role. A guide offering direction is playing a role. A guide who cannot hear disagreement is becoming the role. Playing a role carries responsibility. Becoming the role carries attachment.

The second layer is the ego of image. Image means: how do I appear in the eyes of others? Human beings do not only want to live; they want to appear good, wise, successful, spiritual, sensitive, strong, special. Sometimes we do something not because it is true, but because it makes our image look good. Sometimes we do not admit a mistake because the image may break.

The ego of image is very subtle. It does not only want praise; it also wants to avoid criticism. When someone says something against our image, there is immediate unrest: “What will people think?” “My respect will be lost.” “My spiritual image will break.” Here the seeker must be honest. Am I doing this from truth, or to protect an image? Am I silent because silence is right, or because I fear criticism? Am I humble, or do I want to appear humble?

In modern life, image has become even more delicate. We shape ourselves through photographs, words, messages, videos, and public identity. Seekers are not free from this. A spiritual image can also form: calm, deep, wise, awakened, loving. Then the seeker begins to perform that image. If anger arises, he hides it. If fear arises, he refuses to admit it. A spiritual image can become a layer of ego too.

The third layer is the ego of story. Every person carries a story about himself. This story is made from memories, wounds, achievements, relationships, and conclusions. Someone’s story is, “I struggled a lot.” Another’s is, “I was never

loved.” Another’s is, “I built everything by myself.” Another’s is, “People always leave me.” Events in these stories may be true. But the question is: am I the story?

A story lives in the mind. It is made of memory. Memory comes, goes, and changes. The same event can have a different meaning at different stages of life. But ego turns story into fixed identity: “This happened to me, therefore this is who I am.” This is the ego of story. Witness-consciousness does not erase the story. It sees the story. And once the story is seen, a little distance opens. Then the possibility appears: perhaps I am larger than my story.

One subtle form of story-ego is the identity of being a victim. Sometimes a person becomes so identified with suffering that suffering becomes identity. Pain must be respected. If there has been hurt, it must be seen. But making pain a permanent identity becomes bondage. The victim-story keeps the seeker tied to the past. Every new event is seen through an old wound. Witness-consciousness gently notices: “There is pain. There is an old wound. The mind is identifying as the wounded one.”

Another subtle form is the identity of being special. “I am different.” “No one understands me.” “My experiences are very deep.” “My path is unique.” Sometimes this becomes spiritual: “I have seen what others have not.” This too is ego. Ego comes as greatness, pain, specialness, separation. At its root is the same grip: “I am this.”

How do we see these layers in daily life? When you strongly want your view to be accepted, ask: is this clarity, or is a role speaking? When criticism disturbs you, ask: am I concerned with truth, or with image? When an old event repeats again and again in your mind, ask: has this story become my identity?

When a layer of ego is seen, do not call it failure. It is grace. What was hidden in darkness is now visible. What was moving you unconsciously can now be seen. When a room is dark, dust is not visible. When light comes, dust

appears. The light did not create the dust; it only revealed it. Witness-consciousness is such light.

In this section we have seen three deep layers of ego: role, image, and story. In the next section we will look at one of the most subtle layers - spiritual ego. For now, remember: play your roles, but do not become them. Care for your image where needed, but do not be imprisoned by it. Understand your story, but do not make it your final self.

Practice for Today

Today, notice one moment when you wanted to protect a role, image, or story. Ask: Which role was active? Was I speaking from truth, or protecting an image? Was I seeing the present moment, or reacting from an old story? Then say inwardly: "This role is known. This concern for image is known. This story is known. I can see them."

Third Section - The Subtle Layer of Spiritual Ego

In the previous section we saw the ego of role, image, and story. Now we come to a subtler layer. This layer does not always speak in the language of pride, anger, or control. Sometimes it speaks in the language of peace, humility, knowledge, meditation, service, and spiritual experience. This is why it is difficult to recognize. We will call it spiritual ego.

Spiritual ego means that the same old "I" takes hold of spiritual words, experiences, roles, and achievements, and makes a new identity out of them. Earlier it said, "I am successful." Now it says, "I am aware." Earlier it said, "I

am better than others.” Now it says, “I am more spiritual than others.” The words have changed. The inner grip of “I” may remain the same.

The purpose of sadhana is to make identity light. But if there is no awareness, sadhana itself can become a new identity. A seeker meditates and experiences peace. This is beautiful. A seeker studies and understanding grows. This is helpful. A seeker serves and the heart becomes softer. This is good. But ego can enter here too: “I meditate regularly; I am better than others,” “I have had deep experiences,” “I am no longer like ordinary people.”

Experiences may arise on the path. Peace may arise in meditation. The body may feel light. Thoughts may become quiet. Joy may arise. A sense of vastness may appear. Do not deny these experiences, but do not grasp them either. The experiencer may claim them: “I had the experience of the witness,” “I experienced non-duality,” “Now I understand.” But whatever came and went is an experience. The witness is that which knows even that experience. Respect experiences, but do not turn them into final truth.

A very subtle form of spiritual ego is the ego of humility. A seeker says, “I am nothing,” but inwardly wants others to say, “See how humble he is.” He says, “I do not need respect,” but if respect is not given, hurt arises. Humility is beautiful. Wanting to appear humble is ego. Service is beautiful. Making identity from service is ego. Peace is beautiful. Creating the image of a peaceful person is ego.

Ego can also grasp knowledge. A seeker studies the words: witness, self, Brahman, maya, ego, ignorance, liberation. Understanding becomes clearer. This is good. But then the mind may say: “I know,” “Others do not know,” “My interpretation is superior,” “No one needs to teach me.” This is not knowledge; this is the ego of knowledge. True knowledge makes a person more open, not closed; more gentle, not hard; more able to listen, not only to speak.

The most subtle form of spiritual ego may be the feeling: “I am awakened.” True awareness loosens the grip of “I.” But spiritual ego can turn even

awakening into an achievement. It says, “I am awake; others are asleep.” Here the old division returns: I am above, others are below. This can become a dangerous turn on the path. The seeker must ask: has my understanding increased compassion, or superiority? Have I become simpler, or more special?

Service and renunciation are beautiful parts of spiritual life, but ego can grasp them too. Someone serves, but inwardly feels, “Without me this cannot happen.” Ego has entered. Someone renounces, but inwardly thinks, “See how much I have renounced.” Renunciation has become identity. We do not stop service. We do not reject renunciation. We simply see the “I” hidden within them.

When seekers notice spiritual ego within themselves, they may feel ashamed. They may think, “I was practicing, yet there is ego in me. I am false.” Be careful here. To see spiritual ego is not a failure. It is better seen than hidden. If you can see the wish to appear spiritual, that seeing itself is witness-consciousness. If you can see pride in your experience, that seeing is the beginning. Do not drown in shame. Do not make a new story: “I am full of ego.” Just see.

The opposite of spiritual ego is simplicity. True simplicity does not mean weakness or ignorance. It means there is understanding without display, clarity without hardness, experience without grasping, service without claim, knowledge without superiority. A true seeker knows that whatever has been understood is grace. He speaks, but he can listen. He walks the path, but he does not look down on others.

Whenever something related to practice, knowledge, or experience arises, ask: Am I making identity from this? Is there a feeling of being superior? Is there a desire for recognition, respect, or specialness? If the answer is yes, do not worry. This is the seeing. Then ask gently: Where is this desire known? Where is this pride arising? Does the witness change because of this?

In this section we have looked at spiritual ego. We saw that practice, knowledge, experience, service, humility, and awareness can also be grasped by ego. In the final section, we will gather the whole chapter and understand that ego is not to be fought or killed. It is to be seen.

Practice for Today

Today, notice one moment connected with your practice, knowledge, service, or spiritual identity. Perhaps you felt you understood more than someone else, felt pride in an experience, wanted your humility to be noticed, or secretly called someone “ignorant.” Ask: Was there simplicity of truth here, or a desire to be special? Was there compassion, or superiority? Can I see this spiritual “I” too? Seeing is the beginning of purification.

Fourth Section - Do Not Kill the Ego; See It

In the previous section we saw the subtle layer of spiritual ego. Now we come to a necessary conclusion: do not fight the ego; do not try to kill it. See it in witness-consciousness.

The ego you fight will return as the fighter. It will say, “I am defeating ego,” “I am becoming free from ego,” “I am more egoless than others.” And there it is again. Therefore the path is not war. The path is seeing.

When seekers first see the layers of ego, they may become frightened. “There are so many layers in me. How will I move forward?” Then the mind decides, “I must destroy the ego.” Be careful. If the wish to destroy ego arises from a

hard “I,” it may itself become ego. Sadhana has honesty, but not violence. It has clarity, but not self-punishment.

Seeing ego is simple. When something inside says, “I need respect,” see it. When it says, “I am right and the other is wrong,” see it. When it says, “My image must be protected,” see it. When it says, “I am very spiritual,” see that too. Seeing does not mean immediately correcting it, suppressing it, or justifying it. Seeing means: “A layer of ‘I’ is arising. It is known.”

In daily life, a practical “I” will continue. If someone asks your name, you will answer. If work must be done, you may say, “I will do it.” If the body needs food, you may say, “I am hungry.” This practical “I” is not the problem. The problem begins when the practical “I” becomes final truth. Use the word “I” in life, but inwardly know that it belongs to the level of role and function.

The layers of ego did not form in one day, and they will not loosen in one day. Identification with body began early. Name and role were given by society. Image was shaped by the eyes of others. Story was formed from memory. Spiritual identity may form on the path. These layers must be seen with patience. They loosen through three things: recognizing, allowing, and returning to witness-consciousness.

A simple example may help. Imagine a mirror covered with dust. The dust makes the reflection unclear. If someone says the mirror itself is bad, that is not accurate. The mirror can still reflect; dust is on the surface. You do not fight the dust or break the mirror. You see the dust and clean it gently. Ego-layers are like dust. They may cover the clarity of truth, but they do not destroy it.

When the grip of ego loosens, relationships begin to change. Earlier, hurt came quickly. Now hurt may still arise, but it can be seen. Earlier, disagreement felt like insult. Now disagreement can be heard. Earlier, love contained grasping. Now a little space comes into love. Ego wants

relationships to protect its image, story, and need. Witness-consciousness makes relationships more truthful.

Work also becomes clearer when ego loosens. Earlier, work was used to prove identity. Now work can become a field of learning and service. Earlier, success made the “I” big. Now success can bring gratitude. Earlier, failure made the “I” small. Now failure can become a doorway to learning. When identity is lighter, action does not become weak; it becomes cleaner.

On the path of sadhana, ego may be most subtle. If peace comes in meditation, know it. If peace does not come, know that too. If a deep experience comes, know it. If no experience comes, know that too. If pride arises - “I am a good seeker” - know it. If inferiority arises - “I cannot practice” - know it. The purpose of sadhana is not to collect experiences. The purpose is to know yourself in the midst of all experiences.

Let us gather the journey of this chapter. In the first section we saw the root knot: “I am the body-mind.” In the second section we saw the ego of role, image, and story. In the third section we saw spiritual ego. In this final section we saw that ego is not to be fought or killed. It is to be recognized in witness-consciousness. What is seen clearly begins to lose its grip.

Now the seeker is ready for the next step. So far we have seen: I am not merely the body. I am not merely the mind. I am not merely the experiencer. I am not merely a role, image, story, or spiritual experience. The next chapter will deepen this direction. It is called Neti-Neti, meaning “not this, not this.” This does not mean becoming negative. It means clearly recognizing what I am not, so that what I am becomes self-evident.

Seeing the layers of ego can feel difficult at times, but if it is done in the right spirit, it brings great lightness. You no longer have to make every role your final identity. You no longer have to collapse under every criticism. You no longer have to inflate with every praise. You no longer have to hold every story as “me.” You only have to see.

Wherever the sense of “I” rises strongly, pause and ask: What kind of “I” is this? What is it identifying with? What does it want? Is this too being known? In these questions, the grip of ego begins to soften. Walk slowly. Stay gentle. Do not hide. Do not blame. Simply see. Seeing is the direction of freedom.

Practice for This Week

For the next seven days, watch the layers of ego gently. Whenever the “I” becomes strong, pause and ask: Which layer is active - body identity, opinion, role, image, old story, success or failure, spiritual identity? Then ask: What does this “I” want - respect, security, control, love, recognition, to be proven right, or to appear special? Finally ask: Can I see this “I”? If yes, say inwardly: “This layer of ego is arising. It is known. I can see it.” Do not turn this into self-blame. Let it be a gentle inner cleansing.